

“Diseña tu ciudad” - my experience

I had the opportunity to provide support in the “Diseña tu ciudad” event at Dzidzilché, a little hometown. This activity allowed me to observe a serie of issues about technology, digital gap, and inclusion. In this reflection, I talk about some of the most significant moments I experienced, which make me question the challenges we still face regarding equitable access and use of technology, addressing this with an HCI orientation.

One of the most obvious aspects was the lack of access to mobile devices for many people. Some people didn't have a cell phone, Gmail, and/or phone number, which are necessary to be able to vote on the platform. What they did at Dzidzilché was create a Gmail account to generate QR codes, and they used to put the phone number of the area president, to bridge the digital gap so everyone could vote. This is interesting, since it was assumed that everyone has an email address and a phone number, and there wasn't an alternative in the platform, so they invented one.

Because many people came to vote without registration, registration was the activity that took the longest time. Two ladies around 45 years old were registering citizens and I asked if I could help and they explained to me how to do the registration, generate the QR code, etc. And I was surprised that I used to register two people in the same time it took them to register one, even when it was the first time I used the system and they had already been trained to use it, I think the main reason is that the registration tool was created by people around my age and it was created with features that are intuitive or easy to use for me, but not for people of older generations, I think they adapted to having to use the system instead of having a system designed for them.

One case that blew my mind was when a person who was supposed to scan his QR code, heard "put your hand here," interpreted it literally and placed his hand on the screen instead of his cell phone with the QR code. This demonstrates not only a technological barrier, but also a significant communication and generational gap, since it was obvious to me that they were referring to the QR code, not the person's hand.

Another case was that of a person who decided not to participate because "things shouldn't be done in this way." This demonstrates a rejection of technology by a segment of the population. But I think this is the consequence of the fact that products are often developed without taking into account a segment of the people, in this case, older adults in the hometowns.

This experience allowed me to realize that technology cannot be thought as a universal solution if it is not accompanied by an inclusive approach. Digital gap is a real issue, and we cannot design solutions from the comfort of a city or university without considering the real contexts of use. As future engineers, we have a responsibility to not only create efficient tools, but also accessible, understandable, and adapted to diverse realities.